

THE BUILD CHALLENGE

Code & Lead AI Internship · Team Project + Shark Tank Finals

The Mission

Build an AI tool that solves a real problem for a real person who isn't you. Every team names an actual user — a parent, a teacher, a younger sibling, a local business, a classmate with a specific need — and builds something that person would genuinely use. Same challenge and same scoring for every team, but the problem you pick is yours.

Build time: ~15 hours over the summer. **Stack:** Claude + the Anthropic API + a simple agent loop. **Finale:** Shark-tank pitch in August. One team wins.

The Rules

- **Pick ONE real user** — don't try to fix everything. Solve one specific thing well.
- **Get it in their hands.** That person has to test what you built before finals. Their reaction is part of your story.
- **Show your work on ethics.** Every team answers: “How could this be misused, and what did we do about it?” Safety is part of winning, not an afterthought.
- **Keep it real.** It has to run on demo day. A working small thing beats a broken big thing.

The Five Challenges — One Per Group

Each group gets its own real-world problem that helps real people. They're set at comparable difficulty and the same build stack, so the shark-tank judging stays fair — different problems, same bar.

GROUP 1 · Study Buddy Helping students learn - Sam	
The problem	Studying alone is boring and you can't tell what you actually don't know yet.
Who it helps	A classmate, a younger sibling, or themselves — someone with a real test coming up.
Build	An AI study agent: paste in your notes, it quizzes you, remembers what you keep missing, and drills those topics harder.
Stretch goal	It adapts difficulty as you improve and explains the answer when you get one wrong.
Ethics hook	How do you keep it from just giving away answers — and is its info actually correct?

Milestones (3-Month Arc)

- **June — Lock it in:** Form teams, pick your user and your problem, get it approved. Write a one-sentence pitch.
- **July — Build the engine:** Build the core thing. Get a rough version working, even if it's ugly. First real test with your user.
- **Early Aug — Make it shine:** Polish, fix what your user hated, write your ethics answer, rehearse the pitch.
- **Mid Aug — Finals:** Shark-tank presentations. Live demos. Judges score. A winner is crowned.

How Judges Score (100 pts)

Category	What judges look for	Weight
Does it work?	Live demo runs. It actually does the thing they pitched.	30 pts
Is the problem real?	They named a real user and that person actually tried it.	25 pts
Under the hood	They can explain how it works and answer “what would break this?”	25 pts
The pitch	Clear, confident shark-tank presentation that sells the idea.	20 pts

Same rubric for every team — that’s what keeps it fair when the projects are all different.